

PEBBLEDESK · FREE RESOURCE

CACFP Compliance Checklist for Childcare Centers

CACFP compliance checklist for childcare centers. Covers daily meal counts, menu documentation, income eligibility files, and annual review preparation.

PebbleDesk · pebbledesk.app

CACFP Compliance Checklist for Childcare Centers

CACFP compliance checklist for childcare centers. Covers daily meal counts, menu documentation, income eligibility files, and annual review preparation.

- ☐ Confirm attendance dates match room records.
- ☐ Mark ratio notes that support licensing review.
- ☐ Attach subsidy claim evidence before filing.
- ☐ Keep guardian and pickup updates with the child record.

How to Use This Checklist

Work through this checklist daily, weekly, and monthly. Keep a printed copy at each meal service site and in your administrative files. Items marked with a star (★) are the ones auditors check first — they are the highest-risk areas for findings.

Daily Checklist

Complete these tasks at each meal service (breakfast, AM snack, lunch, PM snack, supper where applicable).

Before the Meal

- ☐ Current menu is posted and matches today's planned meal components
- ☐ All required meal components are available for the meal pattern and age group served
- ☐ Meal count sheet for today is prepared and available at the serving area
- ☐ Staff responsible for the meal count has been identified (this should not be the same person serving food)

During the Meal (Point-of-Service Count) ★

- ☐ Meal count is taken while children are seated and actively eating — not before, not after
- ☐ Count is recorded by classroom/age group, broken down as required by your state agency
- ☐ Each age group is counted separately: infant, toddler, preschool, school-age (as applicable)
- ☐ Only children who received all required meal components are counted
- ☐ Count is physically written on the form at the table — not recalled from memory later
- ☐ A second staff member witnessed or co-signed the count (required by some state agencies — verify your requirement)

After the Meal

- ☐ Menu as served matches the posted menu. If any substitution was made, document it on the menu form with the reason
 - ☐ Infants: breast milk or formula and solid foods are documented separately per infant feeding records
 - ☐ Meal count form is complete, signed, and filed in the daily records folder
 - ☐ Any absent children removed from the count — do not count children who were not present ★
-

Weekly Checklist

Complete at the end of each week, before submitting any attendance or claim data.

Income Eligibility Verification ★

- ☐ Review all income eligibility forms for children who attended this week
- ☐ Check expiration dates — standard forms expire 12 months from the date they are effective
- ☐ Identify any families whose forms expire within the next 30 days; send renewal requests
- ☐ Children with expired or missing eligibility forms should be classified as Tier 2 unless your state agency has a grace period policy (check with your sponsor)
- ☐ New enrollees: eligibility form collected and filed before or at first meal claimed

Claim Reconciliation

- ☐ Total meal counts for the week align with attendance records for the same days
- ☐ No day shows more meals claimed than children enrolled in that age group
- ☐ Days with lower-than-usual counts have a documented reason (holiday, illness outbreak, scheduled closure)
- ☐ Meal counts are stored in a location that can be produced within 5 minutes if an auditor calls

Menu Review

- ☐ Menus for the week are retained in the monthly records folder
- ☐ Any substitutions made during the week are documented on the original menu form
- ☐ Menus meet the current CACFP meal pattern requirements for each age group served (portion sizes, required components)

Monthly Checklist

Complete before submitting your monthly claim.

Claim Preparation ★

- ☐ Monthly meal count totals are compiled from daily count sheets — do not rely on estimates
- ☐ Total counts reconcile to attendance records: if the attendance record shows 15 children on a given day, meal counts for that day should not exceed 15 for that age group
- ☐ Absence days: review your state's allowable absence billing policy for CACFP (this is separate from subsidy billing). Most CACFP programs do not claim meals for absent children
- ☐ Infants: infant feeding records are complete for each day
- ☐ Claim is submitted before your state agency's monthly deadline ★ (late submissions may be disallowed)

Records Filed for the Month

- ☐ All daily meal count sheets filed in monthly folder
- ☐ All menus (as planned and as served) filed in monthly folder
- ☐ Income eligibility forms for all enrolled children are current and accessible
- ☐ Attendance records for the month match the enrollment count used in the claim

Financial Reconciliation

- ☐ Claimed amount is compared to actual reimbursement received when the payment posts
 - ☐ Discrepancies between expected and actual reimbursement are identified and the state agency is contacted if needed
 - ☐ Reimbursement is recorded in your financial records as CACFP income
-

Annual Review Preparation Checklist

Administrative reviews can happen with short notice. Keep your records organized so you can respond within 24 hours.

Records Organization ★

- ☐ Prior 12 months of daily meal count sheets are filed in chronological order, organized by month
- ☐ Menus for all 12 months are retained and match the records for the same period
- ☐ Income eligibility forms are current for all enrolled Tier 1 children
- ☐ Children whose eligibility tier changed during the year have updated forms showing the effective dates
- ☐ Enrollment records match the children included in CACFP claims (no children claimed who were not enrolled)

Documentation Readiness Test

Run this test quarterly — before the annual review, not during it:

- ☐ Pick a random week from 3 months ago
- ☐ Pull the daily meal count sheets for that week in under 5 minutes
- ☐ Confirm the menus for that week are filed and accessible
- ☐ Confirm that all children counted that week have valid income eligibility forms dated before the week
- ☐ Confirm that meal counts for that week do not exceed attendance records for the same days

If you fail any of these tests, fix the filing system now.

Site Preparation

- ☐ Current CACFP participation materials are posted (your state agency provides these)
- ☐ Staff who conduct meal counts can explain the point-of-service counting process
- ☐ You can identify the staff member responsible for CACFP recordkeeping

Common Violations Checklist

Use this list as a self-audit. Check each item to confirm you are not at risk.

Meal Count Violations ★

- ☐ Meal counts are never filled in from memory, from a roster, or at the end of the day — only at point of service
- ☐ Counts for children who left before the meal ended are not included
- ☐ Meal counts do not include children who were absent for any part of the day if they were not present during that specific meal
- ☐ Staff who count meals are trained on point-of-service requirements, not just shown the form

Menu Violations

- ☐ Menus reflect what was actually served, not the planned menu. If the kitchen substituted applesauce for peaches, the menu record shows applesauce
- ☐ All required meal components are present for every claimed meal (e.g., a snack cannot be claimed if only one component was served when two are required)
- ☐ Beverages that do not meet CACFP requirements (sweetened drinks, flavored milk for ages 6+ where not allowed) are not served at claimed meals

Eligibility Violations ★

- ☐ No children are classified as Tier 1 (higher reimbursement rate) without a valid, current income eligibility form on file
- ☐ Eligibility forms are not extended beyond their 12-month effective period without re-collection
- ☐ Eligibility forms are retained even after a child leaves the program — do not destroy records when children disenroll

Administrative Violations

- ☐ Claims are not submitted for months in which the center was not approved to participate
 - ☐ New sites were added to the CACFP agreement before meals were served at those sites, not after
 - ☐ Staff turnover has not left a gap — there is always a qualified person responsible for CACFP recordkeeping
-

Record Retention Summary

Record Type	Minimum Retention
Daily meal count sheets	3 years from end of federal fiscal year
Monthly menus	3 years from end of federal fiscal year
Income eligibility forms	3 years from end of federal fiscal year
Attendance records	3 years from end of federal fiscal year
Monthly claim submissions	3 years from end of federal fiscal year
Training records for CACFP staff	Duration of participation + 3 years

If an audit is ongoing or a finding has been issued, retain all related records until the matter is fully resolved, regardless of the above timelines.